University of St.Gallen

Course and Examination Fact Sheet: Spring Semester 2026

8,384: The UN Sustainable Development Goals from a Legal Perspective

ECTS credits: 4

Overview examination/s

(binding regulations see below)
decentral - Written work, Digital, Individual work individual grade (40%)
Examination time: Term time
decentral - Active participation, Analog, Individual work individual grade (25%)
Examination time: Term time
decentral - Presentation, Analog, Individual work individual grade (35%)
Examination time: Term time

Attached courses

Timetable -- Language -- Lecturer
8,384,1.00 The UN Sustainable Development Goals from a Legal Perspective -- English -- Egli Patricia

Course information

Prerequisites

There is no specific prior knowledge required, however, students should be prepared to work with legal texts and literature.

Learning objectives

Upon successful completion of the course, students will be able to:

- Explain the historical background and the development of the UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs);
- Analyze and evaluate in depth with a paper the legal status of one of the SDGs and its implementation either on international level or on national level in Switzerland;
- Present and discuss the main insights of their papers on the legal status of the SDGs and their implementation and interview another student after her/his presentation about the main challenges regarding the chosen paper topic.

Content

On 25 September 2015, the United Nations General Assembly adopted the Agenda 2030 for sustainable development in the form of a resolution. The central element of the Agenda 2030 are the 17 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), which define the social, economic and environmental goals to be achieved by the 193 member states of the UN by 2030. In principle, the resolutions of the General Assembly of the UN have no binding effect. However, in response to this challenge, international and national actors have developed different strategic legal frameworks to give some aspects of the SDGs legally binding force. Therefore, a differentiated analysis shows that the SDG are not only a declaration with political content, but also have legal dimensions. This course examines these legal dimensions of the SDGs in order to critically assess the effectiveness of the SDGs. The students will discuss the different SDGs, their possible legal dimensions and the implementation of the goals on international and national level. They focus in a paper and a presentation on one specific SDG and analyze either on international or national level the legally binding instruments implementing the goal.

No **Topic**

1 SDG 1: No poverty: International legal status and international implementation

2 SDG 1: No poverty: National legal status and national implementation

3 SDG 2: Zero hunger: International legal status and international implementation

4 SDG 2: Zero hunger: National legal status and national implementation

5 SDG 3: Good health and well-being: International legal status and international implementation

6 SDG 3: Good health and well-being: National legal status and national implementation

7 SDG 4: Quality education: International legal status and international implementation

8 SDG 4: Quality education: National legal status and national implementation

9 SDG 5: Gender equality: International legal status and international implementation

10 SDG 5: Gender equality: National legal status and national implementation

11 SDG 6: Clean Water and sanitation: International legal status and international implementation

12 SDG 6: Clean Water and sanitation: National legal status and national implementation

13 SDG 7: Affordable and clean energy: International legal status and international implementation

14 SDG 7: Affordable and clean energy: National legal status and national implementation

15 SDG 8: Decent work and economic growth: International legal status and international implementation

16 SDG 8: Decent work and economic growth: National legal status and national implementation

17 SDG 9: Industry, innovation and infrastructure: International legal status and international implementation

18 SDG 9: Industry, innovation and infrastructure: National legal status and national implementation

19 SDG 10: Reduced inequalities: International legal status and international implementation

20 SDG 10: Reduced inequalities: National legal status and national implementation

21 SDG 11: Sustainable cities and communities: International legal status and international implementation

22 SDG 11: Sustainable cities and communities: National legal status and national implementation

23 SDG 12: Responsible consumption and production: International legal status and international implementation

24 SDG 12: Responsible consumption and production: National legal status and national implementation

25 SDG 13: Climate action: International legal status and international implementation

26 SDG 13: Climate action: National legal status and national implementation

27 SDG 14: Life below water: International legal status and international implementation

28 SDG 14: Life below water: National legal status and national implementation

29 SDG 15: Life on land: International legal status and international implementation

30 SDG 15: Life on land: National legal status and national implementation

31 SDG 16: Peace, justice and strong institutions: International legal status and international implementation

32 SDG 16: Peace, justice and strong institutions: National legal status and national implementation

33 SDG 17: Partnerships for the goals: International legal status and international implementation

34 SDG 17: Partnerships for the goals: National legal status and national implementation

Structure and indications of the learning and teaching design

The course is structured in three parts:

- Part 1 with interactive lecture on campus: Teaching of the theoretical basics.
- Part 2 with individual work off campus: Individual writing of the term paper and preparation of a presentation with the main insights. In addition, preparation of an interview regarding another student's paper.
- Part 3 with interactive presentations and case analysis on campus: Presentation of the results of the term paper and interviews.

The course approaches the topic in such a way that the basics (historical development of the SDGs, contents of individual SDGs and general legal aspects) are examined in a first interactive lecture (part 1). On the basis of these theoretical principles, students then write a paper and deal either with the legal status and implementation of a specific SDG on international or on national level in Switzerland. The allocation of the predefined paper topics is done on a preference system. In addition, they prepare a presentation with the main insights and an interview regarding another student paper (part 2). Finally, the individual conclusions are discussed in student presentations analyzing the specific case (part 3). Each student will also read the paper of another student (allocated by the chair) and interview her/him after her/his presentation about the main challenges regarding the presented topic.

Literature

Reader with informative texts available on StudyNet, including:

United Nations, 2015, Resolution, Transforming our world: the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development

Biermann/Kanie/Kim, 2017, Global governance by goal-setting: the novel approach of the UN Sustainable Development Goals, Current Opinion in Environmental Sustainability, 2017/26, pp. 26 et seqq.

Breu et al., 2017, Switzerland and the Agenda 2030, Discussion Paper

Ebbersson/Hey, 2022, Introduction: The Sustainable Development Goals, Agenda 2030, and international Law, in: Ebbersson J., Hey E. (eds.) The Cambridge Handbook of the Sustainable Development Goals and International Law, pp. 1 et seqq.

Fernandez Liesa, 2019, The Governance of Sustainable Development Goals in International Law, in: United Nations Institute for Training and Research, SDGs – Main Contribution and Challenges, pp. 51 et seqq.

Huck/Kurkin, 2018, The UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) in the transnational multilevel system, HJIL/ZaöRV 2018/2, pp. 375 et seqq.

Kim, 2016, The Nexus between International Law and the Sustainable Development Goals, Review of European, Comparative & International Environmental Law, 25/1, 15 et seqq.

Pavoni/Piselli, 2016, The Sustainable Development Goals and International Environmental Law: Normative Value and Challenges for Implementation, Veredas Do Direito, 13/26, pp. 13 et seqq.

Seth, 2019, The Negotiation Process of the 2030 Agenda, in: United Nations Institute for Training and Research, SDGs – Main Contribution and Challenges, pp. 13 et seqq.

Swiss Confederation, 2022, Implementing the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development: Voluntary National Review of Switzerland 2022

Students are expected to use appropriate literature for the papers.

Additional information

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Examination information

Examination sub part/s

1. Examination sub part (1/3)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Written work
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Written work
Examination mode	Digital
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous
Examination location	Off Campus
Grading type	Individual work individual grade
Weighting	40%
Duration	--

Languages

Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark

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Examination-aid rule

Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids

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2. Examination sub part (2/3)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Active participation
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Oral examination
Examination mode	Analog
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Synchronous
Examination location	On Campus
Grading type	Individual work individual grade
Weighting	25%
Duration	--

Languages

Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark

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Examination-aid rule

Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids
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3. Examination sub part (3/3)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Presentation
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Oral examination
Examination mode	Analog
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous
Examination location	On Campus
Grading type	Individual work individual grade
Weighting	35%
Duration	--

Languages
Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark
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Examination-aid rule
Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids
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Content

The examination content is based on the reader, on the inputs and discussions in the lectures, and on own research.

The topics for the papers will be assigned by a preference system. The paper of another student for the preparation of the interview will be assigned by the chair after the student papers were turned in.

Literature

Reader available on StudyNet at the start of the semester.

Students are expected to use additional literature for the papers.

Please note

Please note that only this fact sheet and the examination schedule published at the time of bidding are binding and takes precedence over other information, such as information on StudyNet (Canvas), on lecturers' websites and information in lectures etc.
Any references and links to third-party content within the fact sheet are only of a supplementary, informative nature and lie outside the area of responsibility of the University of St.Gallen.

Documents and materials are only relevant for central examinations if they are available by the end of the lecture period (CW21) at the latest. In the case of centrally organised mid-term examinations, the documents and materials up to CW 13 (Monday, 23rd March 2026) are relevant for testing.

Binding nature of the fact sheets:

- Course information as well as examination date (organised centrally/decentrally) and form of examination: from bidding start in CW 04 (Thursday, 22nd January 2026);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for decentralised examinations: in CW 12 (Monday, 16 March 2026);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised mid-term examinations: in CW 14 (Monday, 30 March 2026);
- Examination information (regulations on aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised examinations: two weeks before ending with de-registration period in CW 15 (Monday, 06 April 2026).